

Tactics and Types

Welcome! I'm Filippo and we're going to learn Lean.

Before discussing how to do things, let's have a look at what we're speaking about.



Tactics

Lean relies on the *Curry–Howard isomorphism*, sometimes called the

Propositions-as-Types and Proofs as-Terms Correspondence

(more on this later).

+++In a nutshell

Each statement (or proposition) P is seen as a one-slot drawer: it either contains *one* gadget (a/the proof of P) or nothing. In the first case P is true, in the second it is "false" (or unprovable...).

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Proving $P : \text{Prop}$ boils down to producing a/the term $hp : P$.

This is typically done by

1. Finding somewhere a *true* proposition Q and a term $hq : Q$;
2. Producing a function $f : Q \rightarrow P$ ("an implication");
3. Defining $hp := f\ hq$.

This is often painful: to simplify our life, or to build more convoluted implications, we use *tactics*.

+++ `exact`, `apply`, `intro` and `refl`

- Given a term $hq : Q$ and a goal $\vdash Q$, the tactic `exact hq` closes the goal, instructing Lean to use hq as the sought-for term in Q .
- `apply` is the crucial swiss-knife for *backwards reasoning*: in a situation like

```
hq : Q
f  : Q → P
⊢ P
```

we are done because we can use f to reduce, or back-track, the truth of P to that of Q , that we know (it is hq).

- When wanting to prove an implication $P \rightarrow Q$, the tactic `intro hp` introduces a term $hp : P$: after all, an implication *is* a function, and to define it you give yourself a "generic element in the domain".
- If your goal is $a = a$, the tactic `refl` closes it.

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+++ **rw**

This tactic takes an assumption $h : a = b$ and replaces all occurrences of a in the goal with b . Its variant

```
rw [h] at h1
```

replaces all occurrences of a in $h1$ with b .

- Unfortunately, **rw** is not symmetric: if you want to change b to a use **rw** $[\leftarrow h]$ (type $\leftarrow$ using $\backslash 1$):
beware the square brackets!

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+++ Conjunction ("And", $\wedge$) and Disjunction ("Or", $\vee$)

For both logical connectors, there are two use-cases: we might want to *prove* a statement of that form, or we might want to *use* an assumption of that form.

And

- constructor** transforms a goal $\vdash p \wedge q$ into the two goals $\vdash p$ and $\vdash q$.
- .left** and **.right** (or **.1** and **.2**) are the projections from $p \wedge q$ to p and to q .

Or

- right** and **left** transform a goal $p \vee q$ in p and in q , respectively.
- cases** $p \vee q$ creates two goals: one assuming p and the other assuming q .

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+++ **by_cases**

The **by_cases** tactic, **not to be confused with** **cases**, creates two subgoals: one assuming a premise, and one assuming its negation.

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Types

Lean is based on (dependent) type theory. It is a very deep foundational theory, and we won't dig into all its details.

We'll use it as a replacement for the foundational theory, **replacing sets by types as fundamental objects**.

We do not define *what* types are. They *are*.

Types contain *terms*: we do not call them elements. The notation $x \in A$ is **not** used, and reserved for sets (that will appear, at a certain point). The syntax to say that x is a term of the type T is

```
x : T
```

and reads "the type of x is T ".

Given some term x we can ask Lean what its type is with the command

```
#check x
```

+++ Sets = Types?

No! Of course, you can bring over some intuition from basic set-theory, but **every term has a unique type**.

So, if you encounter

```
x : T, x : S
```

there is certainly a problem, unless $T = S$. In particular, $1 : \mathbb{N}$ and $1 : \mathbb{Z}$ shows that the two 1 's are **different**.

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Prop

There is one kind of particular types, called *propositions* and denoted **Prop**.

Types in it contain *either one term, or no term at all*.

Types of kind **Prop** represent propositions (that can be either true or false). So, $(2 < 3) : \text{Prop}$ and $(37 < 1) : \text{Prop}$ are two *types* in this class, as is $(A \text{ finite group of order } 11 \text{ is cyclic})$.

+++ **True**, **False** and **Bool**

Fundamentally, **Prop** contains only two types: **True** and **False**.

- **True** : **Prop** is a type whose only term is called **trivial**. To prove **True**, you can do **exact trivial**.
- **False** has no term. Typically, you do not want to construct terms there...
- **Bool** is a different type, that contains two *terms*: **true** and **false** (beware the capitalization!).

Bool $\neq$ **Prop**, and we'll ignore **Bool** most of the time.

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Key points to keep in mind

- If $P : \text{Prop}$ then either P has not term at all (" P is false"), or P has a unique term hp (hp is "a witness that P is true"; or a **proof** of P).
- Both $\mathbb{N}$ and $3 < -1$ and $\mathbb{RP}^2$ and $(a+b)^2 = a^2 + 2ab + b^2$ are types, although of different flavour.

☞ → Exercises